



A Look At Available A3 Printers

A3 printers have their own niche. They find customers in design houses, architecture firms, publishing firms, etc. Every printer vendor has at least one A3 model in their portfolio. We tested the latest from Canon—the i9550.

Canon's i9550 is a top-of-the-line A3 model. Being an A3, the printer takes up lots of desk space. Canon has fitted it with foldable paper feeders and output trays to decrease the footprint. Build quality is top-notch, and despite a heavy use of plastic, the printer shows no flimsiness in its design.

The key highlight of the i9550 is its eight-cartridge system. It is an optimised photo-printing device capable of 4800 x 2400 dpi. In our tests, it proved to be an excellent solution, reproducing finer details especially well—thin lines were drawn with a minimum of jaggedness, for example. Similarly, when it comes to colour reproduction, it is quite accurate, and the output is vibrant.

The i9550 also offers CD-R printing, for printing those promotional CD faces. It can be interfaced using USB 2.0 or the FireWire port and is PictBridge-compliant.

A3 printers can cost as little as Rs 20,000, but for the features and print quality of the i9550, you will have to pay Rs 34,500.

cassette, while the HP, Canon and Lexmark offer an optional 250-sheet cassette.

Duplex printing allows you to print on both sides of the page without having to manually turn the paper around. This feature can save a lot of paper, which is always a good thing. Samsung's CLP-500 was the only printer to offer duplex printing. Lexmark offers it as an optional unit, and we recommend buying one.

The drivers that came with the printers were thorough in their ability to set printer parameters and tweak options. The Wipro 4160 has some catching up to do when it comes to the driver interface.

Aesthetically, HP's LaserJet 2550L looks better than the rest. The Samsung CLP-500 sports a distinct design, while Canon and Lexmark have styled their printers in the classic manner—boxy! The Wipro 4610 is a design mystery—the front of the unit cannot be

differentiated from the back; the overall design leaves one frustrated.

To conclude, the Samsung CLP-500 provides more features than most in this league. It was closely followed by Lexmark's C510. The HP and Wipro are on par on the features front.

The Performance

To evaluate the performance of these colourful beasts, we adhered to the same benchmarking procedure that we used to evaluate inkjets. Performance evaluation was done on two parameters, speed and quality.

In Terms of Speed

Ideally, the time taken by each of these printers should not show much variation, but that was not the case. In the text printout test, at the normal setting, Samsung's CLP-500 finished in 13 seconds, while the Lexmark was hot on its heels at 14 seconds. Wipro, at 15 seconds, came in third. The Canon and HP were left behind at 18 and 28 seconds respectively.

The HP, Canon and Wipro have a different setup of colour toners as opposed to the Lexmark and Samsung, which could be a reason for the speed difference.



The HP LaserJet 2550



Score Board



BRAND	Canon	HP	Lexmark	Samsung	Wipro
Model	LBP 2410	Laserjet 2550	C510	CLP 500	4160
Features	8.98	10.00	12.70	13.26	9.24
Resolution	600	600	2400	1200	600
Interface (Parallel / USB / Ethernet)	No / 2.0 / Optional	Yes / 2.0 / Optional	Yes / 2.0 / Optional	Yes / 2.0 / Optional	Yes / 1.1 / Optional
Input buffer (Installed / Expandable)	8 MB / CAPT	64 MB / 192 MB	64 MB / 320 MB	64 MB / 192 MB	32 MB / NA
Paper capacity (Pages)	125	125	250	250	200
Optional Tray support	250	250	250	500	NA
Dual-side printing support	No	No	Optional	Yes	Optional
Performance	36.78	33.21	39.02	38.01	36.90
Speed					
Text Document (Seconds)	18	27	14	18	14
Combi-Document (Seconds)	32	52	68	36	38
Continuous Document (Seconds)	104	124	60	82	105
Photograph (Seconds)	41	160	156	48	60
PPM (Seconds)	13	12	24	15	13
Quality					
Text (Scale of 5)	3.5	3.5	3.5	3.5	3.5
Combi-Document (Scale of 5)	3.1	3.6	3.3	3.0	3.3
Photograph (Scale of 5)	2.9	3.0	2.9	2.9	3.0
Price Index	12.00	17.14	14.63	15.00	18.19
Price (Rupees)	49,995	34,999	41,000	39,990	32,990
Overall Score (Out of 100)	57.76	60.36	66.35	66.27	64.33